

Umpire Continued.

tion. The crew was never reassigned to Duluth, and no one felt too badly about that.

Though he still does not mince words, Froemming confesses that he's gained more finesse in handling angry players and fans.

"In my younger days, it seemed as if there was a hassle just about every night. But you grow with the job. You learn when to talk back and when not to. You just develop a better feel for handling controversy. And you see that anger fades rapidly, so you don't get so uptight about things. Let 'em have their say and then tell 'em it's time to play ball."

The press has always found him quotable. Once an Eau Claire manager rushed Froemming on a disputed call and roared, "You little . . . (expletive deleted)."

In the blink of an eye, Froemming ejected him. Afterward, the umpire told reporters: "I wouldn't have given him the thumb if he'd called me a big so and so, but little? I can't tolerate that."

His long tour of the minors was interrupted by a stint in the Army and a year in which he balked at a contract offered by the Northwest League. (Working the league the previous year, he hadn't seen his family once from April to October). So Froemming wound up sitting out the '64 season, playing third base for a Milwaukee softball team.

It was an uneasy time; a time of lying awake nights wondering if he'd ever again get an umpiring contract. But keeping Froemming out of pro baseball is as difficult as making water flow upstream. Froemming got a job in the Texas League, where long distance travel by car—600 to 900 miles between parks—was common.

There was rejoicing in the Froemming household when his contract was sold to the Triple A Pacific Coast League—the highest level before the majors.

For an umpire, Froemming had said repeatedly, there is only one place to be—the big leagues. Everything else is Poverty Row.

Can a short man make it as a major league umpire? Not many have. Most umpires are of average height or better; some, in fact, stand very tall.

Tallness, society seems to be saying, commands respect and lends itself to authority.

Because of his size, Froemming had a strike against him from the outset—maybe two. And he's no gazelle on the field. Yet, as the super-ump of yesterday, Jocko Conlan, said in his '67 book, "Jocko:" "I talked to some fellows about Froemming. Andy Cohen, the ballplayer, said: 'He reminds me of you, Jocko. He's a nice boy, but he's tough!'"

How can the big leagues deny a fellow like that? Not forever. In 1971 Froemming's dream came true. The news came in a long awaited phone call from

the National League's supervisor of umpires.

"Bruce, we're bringing you up," the supervisor said tersely.

Then 31, Froemming had served 13 long, lean years in the minors. He had worked six leagues—Midwest, Nebraska State, Northwest, Northern, Texas and Pacific Coast—and had the lumps to prove it.

His first regular season game in the majors came in New York's Shea Stadium, where the Mets-Expos game was halted in the sixth inning by a snowstorm. That wasn't so memorable, Froemming says, but the rest of his years in the big time have been chock full of thrills.

He was working first base, for instance, that memorable day in Cincinnati in early '74 when Henry Aaron stroked his historic 714th home run. He won't soon forget, either, umpiring in the '76 World Series. And he was behind the plate that September day in '72 when Chicago's Milt Pappas threw a no-hitter at San Diego. But controversy has a way of finding this gutsy umpire—and that day was no exception.

Pappas was just one out away from a perfect game—he'd retired 26 batters in a row when, after working the count to 1 and 2, he walked a pinch hitter. The Cubs pitcher got the next batter out, so the no-hitter was intact, but he had lost the perfect game (27 straight outs).

Froemming, Pappas said, was the culprit.